

Arguments about the Special Composition Question

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Van Inwagen's arguments against *Contact* etc.

- Against *Contact*
 1. No quarks or electrons are in contact. But there are objects composed of quarks and electrons. So *Contact* is false.
 2. If *Contact* is true, then when you and I are shaking hands, we compose something. But it is not the case that when you and I are shaking hands, we compose something. So *Contact* is false.
- Variants of argument 2 are also used against *Fastening*, *Cohesion* and *Fusion*.

- Why does van Inwagen claim that we don't compose anything when we're shaking hands?

It is a basic conviction of mine that this theory is wrong... I cannot prove this thesis, for I know of no propositions more plausible than itself from which it could be derived... I will content myself for the present by pointing out that if you disagree with me about Contact, you face a host of metaphysical problems that I avoid... For example, suppose that I were to touch your knee with my elbow. Would the object that came into existence when this happened be the same one that came into existence when we shook hands or a different one? (p. 36)

The argument against Universalism

- A principle about composition
 - (*) It never happens that some things compose different objects, either at different times or at the same time.
- In other words: it never happens that the x s compose y at t_1 , and the x s compose z at t_2 , and $y \neq z$.

- The argument:

(A) I exist now and I existed 10 years ago.

(B) I am an organism, and I have always been an organism.

(C) Every organism is composed of atoms at every moment of its existence.

(D) Consider any organism that existed 10 years ago; all of the atoms that composed it 10 years ago still exist.

(E) Consider any organism that exists now and existed 10 years ago; none of the atoms that now compose that organism is among those that composed it 10 years ago.

(F) If Universalism is true, then (*) is true.

Therefore, Universalism is false.

- We can derive a contradiction from (A)-(F) and Universalism, as follows.

By (A)-(C), there are some atoms that composed me ten years ago. By (D), those atoms still exist. By (A) and (E), they do not now compose me. But by Universalism, they compose something. So they compose different things at different times; so (*) is false. But by Universalism and (F), (*) is true. So (*) is both true and false: contradiction.

- Why believe (F)?

(i) Consider an object that is composed of the blocks at t , when they are widely scattered and moving rapidly in relation to one another. How long does it last? Only two answers seem possible. (1) It doesn't last at all; it exists only at t . (2) It lasts as long as its constituent blocks do. Any compromise between these two answers would be intolerably arbitrary. (77)

(ii) If (1) is true of the blocks, then *positional essentialism* is true: 'not only the identities of the parts of a whole are essential to that whole but their relative positions and attitudes as well. But positional essentialism isn't true.

(iii) But if (2) is true of the blocks, (*) must be true.

- How might Universalists resist this argument?
- One possibility: claim that it sometimes happens that some things simultaneously compose two different objects.
 - I assume that any two objects which are composed by the same things at some time will be in the same place at that time.

- How would this help?
 - We might reject step (iii).
 - A possible view: when the blocks are scattered, they compose just one object, which they will compose as long as they all continue to exist. But when they come to be arranged in some interesting way, they will come to compose some other object (probably a shorter-lived one) *in addition*.
 - Or we might reject step (i)
 - A proponent of the doctrine of temporal parts and Universalism might want to say that the blocks compose lots and lots of things at any given time.

Van Inwagen's Proposed Answer to the Special Composition Question

The xs compose something iff the activity of the xs constitutes a life, or there is only one of the xs.

- What is a life? A certain kind of self-maintaining event that is 'reasonably well-individuated' and 'jealous' (it never happens that the activity of the same things constitutes two different lives).

- A consequence of this view: there are no tables or computers or statues or lumps of clay or ships or grains of sand.... For surely if there was such a things as a table, etc., it would have to be composed by some things whose activity did not constitute a life (and which were more than one in number).
- NB: when you're describing this aspect of van Inwagen's views, pay attention to the paragraph on pp. 99-100.

Is this consistent with ordinary belief?

- The analogy with ‘the sun went behind the elms’.

- Distinguish several different questions:
 - Do most people believe that there are chairs?
 - Do most people have *good reason* to believe that there are chairs?
 - When ordinary people utter sentences like ‘there are two very valuable chairs in the next room’, do they thereby express a proposition that could not be true unless there were chairs?
 - Would there have to be chairs for *sentences* like ‘there are two very valuable chairs in the next room’ to be true?